🗓️ Timeline & Cartoons: BASIC Cartoon Handout

US History · Unit 1 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · how to read a political cartoon

Name: _____

Use BASIC on every political cartoon this year.

B.A.S.I.C. in your own words

1. B (Background): How does background knowledge help a person understand a political cartoon?

2. Why is it harder to understand cartoons from the 1800s than today's cartoons?

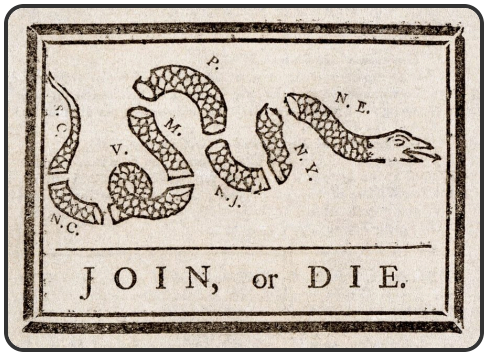
3. A (Argument): What is the goal of a political cartoon? Where in a newspaper do you find them, and why not in the comics section?

4. S (Symbols): How are symbols used? List 3 symbols most Americans would recognize.

5. I (Indicators): Where can you find indicators, and why read all of them?

6. C (Caricature): Why is caricature used? Why are stereotypes in old cartoons a problem?

Practice 1: Join, or Die (1754)

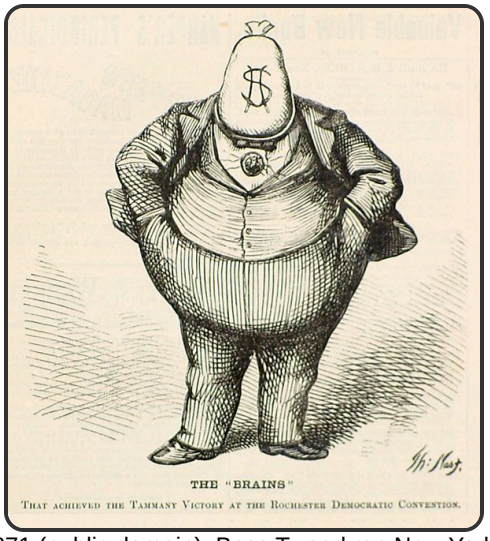


“Join, or Die.” Benjamin Franklin, 1754 (public domain)

7. Fill in the table.

B	A	S	I	C

Practice 2: The “Brains” (1871)



“The ‘Brains.’” Thomas Nast, 1871 (public domain). Boss Tweed ran New York City politics and stole millions.

8. Fill in the table.

B	A	S	I	C